

Spain Family Trip — Barcelona → Madrid

Dates: Wednesday, July 8 → Tuesday, July 14, 2026 (7 days / 6 nights)

Travelers: 4 — Mom & Dad (74), you & your brother (29)

Route: Land Barcelona 9:00 AM Jul 8 → 3 nights Barcelona → AVE train Sat Jul 11 → 3 nights Madrid → fly to NY/NJ Tue Jul 14

Planning notes for a multigenerational trip: central hotels chosen for shortest distances to your actual wishlist, gentle pacing for your parents, timed morning tickets to beat the July heat (highs ~30–36°C / 86–97°F), taxis over long walks, and afternoon rest gaps before the late Spanish dinners.

BOOK TODAY — the trip starts in 3 days

These sell out or get expensive fastest. Book in this order, today:

Priori	What	Slot to book	Price (pp)	Where
1	**Sagrada Família** — Thu Jul 9	**9:00 AM** entry (Quiet Hour)	€26 adult / €21 senior; towers +€10 (sons only)	sagradafamilia.org/en/tickets-individuals
2	**Train BCN→Madrid** — Sat Jul 11	**AVE 03080, 8:25 AM** (nonstop)	~€60–110 Standard, ~€90–140 Confort/Premium	renfe.com
3	**Hotels** (both cities)	Jul 8–11 BCN / Jul 11–14 MAD	—	direct or your booking site
4	**Spotify Camp Nou Experience** — Fri Jul 10	**9:30 AM** guided session (English)	from €69	fcbarcelona.com/en/tickets/camp-nou-experience
5	**Bernabéu Tour** — Mon Jul 13	**9:00 AM** opening (or €44 Flexible-time)	€37 online	realmadrid.com/en-US/tour-bernabeu
6	**Royal Palace** — Sun Jul 12	~10:00 AM timed entry	see site	entradas.patrimoni nacional.es
7	**Tuk-tuk tour Madrid** — Sat Jul 11	~6:30 PM, private, 1.5–2 hr	varies	book a rated operator online in advance
8	**Casa Batlló (interior)** — Thu Jul 9	~5:00 PM timed entry	from ~€29 (senior discount)	casabatllo.es
9	**Park Güell** — Fri Jul 10	~6:30 PM golden hour	~€10–18 (check site)	parkguell.barcelona
10	**Flamenco tablao** — Sun Jul 12	early show (~7 PM — confirm times)	~€50–65 with drink	Corral de la Morería (corraldelamoreria.com)
11	**Reina Sofía (Guernica)** — Mon Jul 13	~4:00 PM (open Mondays)	~€12	museoreinasofia.es

- Sagrada tickets are **nominative — names must match photo ID**, and July 2026 is centenary-year peak season: morning slots genuinely can sell out days ahead. If the 9:00–10:00 window for Jul 9 is gone, take anything before 11:00, or check Tiqets (authorized reseller with separate allotments), or book the guided-tour ticket (sells out slowest). ⚠️ *A teachers'-strike protest was intermittently restricting basilica access as of July 5 — re-check sagradafamilia.org the morning of your visit.*

- Restaurants: **Botín, Casa Lucio, 7 Portes** — call/book online today too. The

ultra-fine-dining rooms (Disfrutar, DiverXO) are realistically gone at 3 days' notice, but cancellations happen — try their sites; **StreetXO** takes walk-ins.

At a Glance

Day	Date	Base	Highlights
1	Wed Jul 8	Barcelona	Land 9:00 AM, settle in, Gothic Quarter + La Boqueria + beach sunset
2	Thu Jul 9	Barcelona	**Sagrada Família 9:00 AM (reserved)**, beach/pool, **Casa Batlló interior 5 PM**
3	Fri Jul 10	Barcelona	**Camp Nou tour 9:30 AM**, beach afternoon, **Park Güell golden hour**
4	Sat Jul 11	→ Madrid	**AVE 8:25→11:27**, lunch at Sol, evening tuk-tuk tour + Plaza Mayor
5	Sun Jul 12	Madrid	Royal Palace, **Mercado de San Miguel**, shopping, **flamenco show**, La Latina
6	Mon Jul 13	Madrid	**Bernabéu tour 9:00 AM**, **Guernica at Reina Sofía**, San Ginés finale
7	Tue Jul 14	→ NY/NJ	Midday nonstop from Madrid-Barajas

Where to Stay — chosen by distance to YOUR list

Barcelona (3 nights: Jul 8-11)

Your Barcelona list = Sagrada Família, Camp Nou, beach, old town, and the train station. I mapped both candidate hotels against every stop:

Destination	Majestic Hotel & Spa (Pg. de Gràcia)	Hotel Arts (beachfront)
Sagrada Família	**8-10 min taxi / 23 min flat walk**	10-15 min taxi
Gothic Quarter	**~24 min flat walk / 8 min taxi**	8-12 min taxi
Barceloneta beach	10-15 min taxi	**on the sand (0 min)**
Park Güell	**11-15 min taxi**	15-25 min taxi
Camp Nou	**10-15 min taxi**	16-25 min taxi
Sants station (train day)	**7-12 min taxi / 12 min metro L3**	12-20 min taxi

Top pick — Majestic Hotel & Spa (5★, Passeig de Gràcia 68). Total distance to your non-beach stops is roughly **half** of Hotel Arts' (≈ 16 km vs ≈ 29 km of taxi legs), it has a rooftop pool with Sagrada Família views for the afternoon heat breaks, and Casa Batlló/La Pedrera are on its doorstep. The beach becomes one short taxi ride on beach afternoons.

Beach-first alternative — Hotel Arts Barcelona (5★, Port Olímpic). If waking up on the sand matters more than shorter sightseeing hops, this stays the pick: beach at the door, beachfront pool, spa — you'll just taxi 10-25 min to everything else.

(W Barcelona and Sofitel/Pullman Skipper remain solid beachfront backups.)

Madrid (3 nights: Jul 11-14)

Top pick — Four Seasons Hotel Madrid (5★, Calle de Sevilla 3). The distance check confirmed it's near-perfect for your list — six of your stops are a flat

walk under 13 minutes:

Destination	From the Four Seasons
Puerta del Sol	**5 min walk**
Chocolatería San Ginés	**8-9 min walk**
Bershka (Gran Vía 25)	**8 min walk**
Zara flagship (Gran Vía 34)	**10 min walk**
Plaza Mayor	**9-11 min walk**
Mercado de San Miguel	**12-13 min walk**
Royal Palace	16-18 min walk or 7-10 min taxi
Santiago Bernabéu	10-18 min taxi (~€10-15 for all 4)
Atocha station	6-10 min taxi (~€7-9)

(Alternatives if it's sold out at 3 days' notice: Thompson Madrid or NH Collection Suecia — both keep everything within the same walkable square kilometer.)

Booking tip for both cities: two connecting/adjacent rooms near the lift, and a step-free bathroom for your parents.

Train — Barcelona → Madrid, Saturday July 11 (verified timetable)

Important 2026 reality check: Adif track works add ~25-30 min to *every* train on this line until ~December 2026 — so trips take **3 h+**, **not the advertised 2 h 30**, frequencies are reduced, and fares are high. Verified departures from Renfe's official data for **Saturday, July 11, 2026** (all arrive **Madrid-Puerta de Atocha**):

Train	Departs Sants	Arrives Atocha	Duration	Stops
Renfe AVE 03062	5:50	9:40	3h50	5
Renfe AVE 03302	6:35	9:52	3h17	1
Ouigo (budget)	7:35	11:05	3h30	1
Renfe AVE 03082	8:00	11:44	3h44	4
Renfe AVE 03080	**8:25**	**11:27**	**3h02**	**nonstop**
Renfe AVE 03092	9:00	12:24	3h24	2
Renfe AVE 03304	9:55	13:44	3h49	5

Book the 8:25 AVE 03080 — the only nonstop and the fastest morning train, at a civilized hour for your parents, landing you in Madrid at 11:27 with the whole afternoon and evening ahead. If you want to arrive even earlier, the **6:35 (arr. 9:52) is the early-bird option**. In Elige Confort or Premium **you get wide 2+1** seats, at-seat meal service, and Renfe's free **Atendo** assistance for your parents (request it when booking — they'll help with luggage and boarding at both stations).
Notes: iryo's morning times couldn't be verified (its old 8:45 no longer runs — check iryo.eu directly); Ouigo is cheapest but charges for luggage beyond one cabin bag + one carry-on each. Availability is live-only — book on renfe.com today.

✈ Flight home — Madrid → NY/NJ, Tuesday July 14 (nonstop options)

Flight	Departs MAD	Arrives	Airport	Barajas terminal
United UA50	10:50	13:15	Newark (EWR)	T1
American AA95	10:25	12:30	JFK	T4
Iberia IB211	~12:30	14:55	JFK	T4 (boards T4S)
Delta DL127	12:45	~15:00	JFK	T1
Iberia IB325	16:20	~18:00	JFK	T4 — lands into evening rush

If you haven't booked yet, the **midday Iberia IB211 or Delta DL127** fit your parents best: taxi from the hotel ~**8:15-8:30 AM** (fixed **€33 flat fare** to the airport, ~30-45 min), airport by 9:00 (Iberia recommends up to 4 h for US-bound security), and a mid-afternoon landing in New York. Iberia/American board from the **T4S satellite** — budget an extra 30-45 min for the airside train + passport control. *Air Europa's Tuesday service couldn't be confirmed — avoid unless verified.* If your flight is already booked, just apply the same timeline: **leave the hotel** ~4 hours before departure.

Day-by-Day

Day 1 — Wed Jul 8 · Land in Barcelona (9:00 AM)

- **9:00 AM:** land at BCN; taxi to the hotel (~25-35 min, ~€35-40). Rooms likely won't be ready — request early check-in when booking; otherwise leave bags and have a slow coffee/brunch nearby.

- **Afternoon:** nap/pool — everyone will be jet-lagged; protect this rest window.
- **Evening:** gentle **Gothic Quarter + La Rambla** stroll while it cools — duck into **La Boqueria market** on the way (stalls close ~8 PM) for ten minutes of the famous food stalls and a fresh-juice stop — then an early tapas dinner. If energy allows, finish with a **sunset drink at a beach chiringuito** on Barceloneta.

Early night — tomorrow has a 9:00 reservation.

Day 2 — Thu Jul 9 · Sagrada Família (reserved) + Beach

- **8:40 AM:** arrive at the basilica for security (15 min early). **9:00 AM entry** — the "Quiet Hour" slot: **thinnest crowds of the day, morning sun through the blue Nativity-façade glass**, and cool air. Parents use step-free **Entrance B (Carrer de la Marina)** — **lifts throughout, free loaner wheelchairs if wanted**.

- **Towers:** you and your brother can add tower access (+€10) — but Mom & Dad should skip it: the descent is 300-500 narrow spiral stairs on foot, no lift down.

- **Late morning:** stroll/taxi back via **Passeig de Gràcia** — La Pedrera façade on the way (steps from the Majestic).

- **Afternoon: beach + pool** heat break — swim at Barceloneta or laze at the rooftop.

- **5:00 PM: Casa Batlló — inside this time** (timed entry, ~90 min). Gaudí's dragon-spine house 2 minutes from the Majestic: the blue-tiled light well and whale-rib attic are the best interior in Barcelona. Air-conditioned with lifts — the ideal late-afternoon slot for your parents.

- **Evening:** dinner in the Eixample or El Born; optional **sunset harbor cruise** from Port Vell (zero walking, great for the parents).

Day 3 — Fri Jul 10 · FC Barcelona's Camp Nou + Beach

- **9:15 AM:** taxi to **Spotify Camp Nou, Access 15 (C/ Arístides Maillol)** — arrive 15 min before the **9:30 guided Experience session** (latecomers get downgraded to museum-only). ~2 h: museum + trophy gallery + Messi Zone, immersive 360° room, panoramic view of the rebuilt bowl, and guided access into the first-tier stands. Note for Mom & Dad: everything is step-free with lifts **up to** the panoramic viewpoint; **the final descent into the stands is stairs-only — they** can wait at the viewpoint while you two go down. (Renovation continues: no dressing rooms/pitch walk on the standard route yet.)

- **Lunch + afternoon:** back east for a **final beach afternoon** — Barceloneta or the quieter Nova Icària stretch.

- **6:30 PM: Park Güell — now a committed stop** (timed tickets sell out like the Sagrada's; book today). Taxi to the **upper entrance** so nobody climbs the hill; golden hour gives the coolest air and prettiest light on the mosaic terrace. If the parents are out of energy by Friday evening, you two go alone while they rest — the **Montjuïc cable car** is their low-effort alternative.

- **Night:** seafood/paella farewell dinner (7 Portes or Can Majó). Pack for the train.

Day 4 — Sat Jul 11 · AVE to Madrid + Old-Madrid Evening

- **7:40 AM:** taxi to **Barcelona-Sants** (10–15 min; Atendo assistance meets you if requested).

- **8:25 AM: AVE 03080 nonstop → Madrid-Atocha 11:27.**

- **11:45 AM:** taxi to the Four Seasons (6–10 min); drop bags, lunch near **Puerta del Sol (5-min walk — you're staying on top of it).**

- **Afternoon:** siesta — travel day + tonight is busy.

- **~6:30 PM: Tuk-tuk tour** (pre-booked, private, 1.5–2 h): yes, the touts by Plaza Mayor seem scammy — that's why you book a rated operator ahead — but the format is genuinely perfect here: a fun, zero-walking sweep of the Royal Palace exterior, cathedral, Plaza de Oriente, Gran Vía, and old town in the golden hour.

Ask the operator to end the route at the Temple of Debod — the real ancient Egyptian temple with Madrid's best sunset view, for zero extra effort.

- **Evening:** dinner under the arcades of **Plaza Mayor.**

Day 5 — Sun Jul 12 · Royal Palace, San Miguel & Shopping

- **10:00 AM: Royal Palace** (timed tickets; lifts available) + **Plaza de Oriente.**

- **~12:30 PM:** flat 10-min walk to **Mercado de San Miguel** — your must-do. Graze long and slow: jamón, croquetas, oysters, vermouth. Arriving before ~1 PM beats the worst crush.

- **Afternoon:** siesta.
- **~5:00 PM: Puerta del Sol** (Km 0 plaque, the bear-and-strawberry-tree statue), then **Bershka (Gran Vía 25)** and the **Zara flagship (Gran Vía 34)** — 8–10 min walks from the hotel. Fold in the **Spanish McDonald's** stop here for the menu comparison the four of you can argue about at dinner.

- **~7:00 PM: Flamenco at a top tablao** — seated, air-conditioned, and one of Spain's great live experiences; take the **early show** so the night stays easy for your parents. First choice **Corral de la Morería** (Calle Morería 17, near the Royal Palace — the world's most famous tablao); **Torres Bermejas** near Gran Vía is the closer-to-the-hotel backup. Book today and confirm exact showtimes.

- **~9:15 PM:** short taxi to **La Latina** — Sunday is its big tapas night (Cava Baja) — for a late-but-light bite, or Casa Lucio if you snagged a table.

Day 6 — Mon Jul 13 · Real Madrid's Bernabéu + Sweet Finale

- **8:45 AM:** taxi up the Castellana (~15 min, one cab fits all four, ~€10–15).

9:00 AM Bernabéu tour at opening — museum with all 15 European Cups, the renovated bowl with its wraparound 360° screen, changing rooms and dugout. ~2 h. Heads-up: the route includes **numerous stretches of stairs** — if either parent would struggle, the €44 Flexible ticket plus the club's lift-served partial route (contact them ahead) is the safer setup.

- **Lunch + siesta.**
- **~4:00 PM: Reina Sofía for *Guernica***** — **Picasso's masterpiece is arguably** Spain's most important artwork, the museum is **open Mondays** (it closes Tuesdays), fully accessible, and this is a one-hour in-and-out visit: Guernica, the rooms around it, done. Gentler alternatives if the family prefers: **Retiro Park** (flat, shady, rowboats) or the **Prado** (benches throughout).

- **Evening:** farewell dinner — **Sobrino de Botín** (world's oldest restaurant, 1725; book now) — then **Chocolatería San Ginés** for the churros-and-thick-chocolate finale, 8 min from the hotel. Pack tonight.

Day 7 — Tue Jul 14 · Fly home to NY/NJ

- **~8:15 AM:** taxi to Barajas (€33 flat fare, 30–45 min) for a midday nonstop — airport ~4 h ahead per Iberia's US-bound guidance (T4S flyers: extra 30–45 min).
- Land New York mid-afternoon. ¡Buen viaje!

Your Wishlist — all covered

- ☑ **Mercado de San Miguel** — Day 5, long grazing lunch
- ☑ **Tuk-tuk tour** (reputable, pre-booked) — Day 4 evening

- ✓ **Royal Palace** — Day 5 · **Plaza Mayor** — Day 4 evening · **Puerta del Sol** — Days 4–6
- ✓ **Sagrada Família basilica** — reserved **9:00 AM slot, Thu Jul 9**
- ✓ **Camp Nou (FC Barcelona)** — Day 3, 9:30 AM Experience
- ✓ **Santiago Bernabéu (Real Madrid)** — Day 6, 9:00 AM tour
- ✓ **Beach time** — Days 1, 2 & 3
- ✓ **Zara flagship + Bershka** — Day 5 (8–10 min walk from hotel)
- ✓ **Spanish McDonald's** — Day 5 · **San Ginés** — Day 6 finale

Don't-miss additions folded in:

- ✓ **La Boqueria market** — Day 1 evening stroll
- ✓ **Casa Batlló interior** — Day 2, 5:00 PM
- ✓ **Park Güell** — Day 3, 6:30 PM golden hour (committed — book today)
- ✓ **Flamenco tablao** — Day 5, ~7:00 PM early show
- ✓ **Guernica (Reina Sofía)** — Day 6, ~4:00 PM (open Mondays)

Top-Tier Restaurant Picks

With 3 days to go: **book the classics today by phone/web**; treat the 3-star rooms as lottery tickets (check for cancellations). First sitting ~8 PM suits your parents best.

Barcelona

- **Splurge: Disfrutar** (3★ Michelin, ranked world's #1 — cancellations only at this notice), **Lasarte** (3★), or the warmer **Cinc Sentits** (1★).

- **Iconic & family-friendly: 7 Portes** (paella institution, est. 1836),

Els Quatre Gats (Picasso's haunt), **Can Majó** (beachside paella).

- **Tapas:** Cal Pep, El Xampanyet, Quimet & Quimet — go at opening for seats.

Madrid

- **Splurge: DiverXO** (3★, Spain's hardest table — cancellation-watch only), **DSTAgE** (2★), or walk-in-friendly **StreetXO**.

- **Iconic & family-friendly: Sobrino de Botín** (oldest restaurant on Earth, 1725 — wood-oven suckling pig, steps from Plaza Mayor), **Casa Lucio** (huevos rotos), **Taberna La Bola** (cocido madrileño).

- **Tapas:** San Miguel market grazing + Cava Baja crawl in La Latina (Sunday!).

Comfort & Pacing (traveling with parents at 74)

- **Heat plan:** all big sights are booked at 9:00–9:30 AM starts; afternoons are pool/siesta; evenings are for squares, shopping, and dinners.

- **Taxis liberally:** every leg above is one cheap cab; a standard taxi seats all 4.
- **Renfe Atendo:** free assistance at both stations — request with the ticket.
- **Stairs watch:** Sagrada towers (skip for parents), Camp Nou stands descent (viewpoint wait), Bernabéu route (contact club if concerned). Everything else is step-free or lift-served.

- **Dining:** first sitting ~8 PM, or big lunch + light tapas night.
- **Pharmacies** (green cross) everywhere; carry meds in original packaging + a list

of generic names; confirm travel insurance covers all four.

Sources

- Renfe official GTFS timetable feed (service date 2026-07-11) — [renfe.com](https://www.renfe.com) — <https://www.renfe.com> · Ouigo timetables — <https://www.ouigo.com/es/horarios-trenes-ouigo> · [Seat61 Barcelona-Madrid](https://www.seat61.com/trains-and-routes/barcelona-to-madrid-by-train.htm) — <https://www.seat61.com/trains-and-routes/barcelona-to-madrid-by-train.htm>
- Sagrada Família — official tickets — <https://sagradafamilia.org/en/tickets-individuals> · hours & access — <https://sagradafamilia.org/en/schedules-how-to-get>
- FC Barcelona — Camp Nou Experience — <https://www.fcbarcelona.com/en/tickets/camp-nou-experience> · [tours-are-back announcement](https://www.fcbarcelona.com/en/club/news/4440096/spotify-camp-nou-tours-are-back) — <https://www.fcbarcelona.com/en/club/news/4440096/spotify-camp-nou-tours-are-back>
- Real Madrid — Bernabéu Tour — <https://www.realmadrid.com/en-US/tour-bernabeu/individual>
- Iberia US-bound arrival guidance — <https://www.iberia.com/us/time-limit/> · Madrid airport taxi flat fare — <https://www.madrid-traveller.com/madrid-airport-to-the-city-center/> · MAD-JFK nonstops — <https://www.flightconnections.com/flights-from-mad-to-jfk>
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